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Negotiating Meaning: Cypriot Leaders and the EU's Role in Conflict Resolution

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ABSTRACT
This article examines how Europe-related discourses were used on Twitter in the Cyprus peace process. Europe and the EU have long shaped public debate on the issue. By analyzing tweets from Greek-Cypriot and Turkish-Cypriot leaders across three key periods (2015–2021), the study traces shifting narratives about Europe's role. The findings show how Europe's role in the Cyprus problem was dynamically reframed on Twitter throughout these phases..

KEYWORDS
Discourse; Cyprus problem; Europe; Twitter; dialogical approach

Introduction

In this article, we examine the recontextualization of Europe's meaning in the public discourse of societies grappling with prolonged conflict, with a focus on Cyprus's unresolved issue lasting over 40 years. We delve into how Cypriot community leaders utilize Europe in their discourses to communicate messages about the Cyprus problem to the public.

Although the Republic of Cyprus (RoC) became an EU member state in 2004, the island remains divided, and the Turkish-Cypriot (TC) community lives under an internationally recognized state-entity only acknowledged by Turkey. This study concentrates on Twitter, in the period 2016–2017 before its take over by Elon Musk in 2022 and change to X in April 2023. Twitter at that time offered a more open platform to intercommunal communication compared to the segregated traditional media spheres in Cyprus for over 40 years. Recent political developments in Cyprus with the election of a social media influencer, Fidias Panayiotou, in the EU parliament and his recent pro-reconciliation discourse between the two communities suggest that any renewed effort to negotiate the Cyprus issue will involve influential public debates on social media.

Our focus in this research is on the official Twitter accounts of the two Cypriot community leaders, examining how they construct meaning around Cyprus problem-related issues using Europe and the EU during and after the last round of negotiations to resolve the Cyprus problem which started in 2015 with the election of pro-reconciliation and pro-federation leader of the Turkish Cypriot community Mustafa Akinci and finished with the collapse of negotiations between Mustafa Akinci and Nicos Anastasiades in July 2017 at Crans Montana. Elected leaders play a crucial role as elected representatives of the communities, actively involved in negotiations to resolve the Cyprus problem every five years.

While there is a growing body of literature on the political use of Twitter, research on its use by leaders representing rival sides in divided societies undergoing negotiations for ethnic conflict resolution is limited. In societies like Cyprus, where the public sphere is segregated, and negotiations occur behind closed doors, Twitter has become a significant tool for community leaders. It goes beyond political diplomacy, serving as a means to develop and disseminate discourses about negotiations, shaping the "trustworthy source" through which the public constructs meaning around Cyprus problem-related issues. This article addresses the knowledge gap on how Twitter functions as a diplomatic tool for political leaders, not just for electoral purposes but also for framing issues central to the negotiating peace process.

In this context, this study examines how Cypriot leaders actively construct and negotiate the discourse surrounding the EU's role in the Cyprus peace process, revealing the dynamic interplay between political narratives and the evolving perceptions of Europe as a facilitator in conflict resolution.

Lastly, we should clarify that while this study focuses on Twitter as the primary platform for analysis, we acknowledge the evolving nature of social media technologies, especially with the recent changes under Elon Musk's leadership. Twitter was chosen for its real-time

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engagement and public visibility, which are crucial for understanding political discourse. Additionally, at the time of our research, Twitter allowed researchers to scrape large volumes of data for analysis and featured a high proportion of public accounts, enabling access to a wealth of information. We also considered other platforms like Facebook and Instagram, but determined that Twitter's unique characteristics best aligned with our research objectives.

Additionally, in the context of the post-Fidias era, Elon Musk's recent comments regarding the Cyprus peace workshop in Washington highlight the ongoing relevance of international perspectives in the negotiation process.

Twitter and politics

It seems that world's leaders understand the power that Twitter has given them as a channel of communication with the public as according to Twiplomacy (2020), "the governments of only four countries do not have a Twitter presence, namely Laos, North Korea, Sao Tome and Principe and Turkmenistan" (Twiplomacy, 2020). As Broersma and Graham put it "tweeting offers politicians the opportunity for a virtual handshake and direct conversation with voters" (2015, p. 96).

Scholars, who have recognized the increasing activity of politicians on Twitter, have examined the links between the leaders' or politicians' Twitter activity with their political power. Gainous and Wagner (2014) examined how the use of social media by candidates generated votes in US elections to argue that politicians' use of social media, like Twitter, can make them win or lose elections. They also suggest that the new interactions among people and new relationships that are developed online affect political engagement and participation (Gainous & Wagner, 2014).

Researchers who examine the phenomenon of Twiplomacy, however, are constantly questioning as Sykes successfully puts it: "what comes first, the power or the tweet?" (Sykes, 2014). These studies usually compare the communication practices followed by political actors both offline and online and most of them conclude that the political actors that dominate the offline political discourse tend to do so in the social media context too (Jungherr et al., 2014; Jürgens et al., 2011; Klinger, 2013).

Other scholars have focused on the way politicians use their social media accounts, Twitter in particular, to reach or to interact with the public. Aharony (2012, p. 606) after studying the tweeting activity of three world leaders, concluded that they use Twitter "as a channel that allows them to convey their own agenda to the public as what they say stays unfiltered and uncensored by the national and local media."

Apart from the use of Twitter as a diplomatic tool for increasing the political power, research on the political use of Twitter in segregated societies as a tool for developing discourses that could either facilitate digital intergroup contact (Zezelj et al., 2017) or reinforce intergroup conflict is yet limited. The potential of the Internet as a space where "Net-based public spheres" could be developed in order to facilitate communication among heterogeneous groups has been highlighted Dahlgren (2005) however, not many studies have examined Internet's potential on affecting peace processes in post-conflict and conflict transformation settings. The few ones that did have concluded that when political leaders use Twitter for constructing meaning around the issues of intergroup conflict that concern their societies, they do so in order to legitimize or delegitimize those involved in the conflict (Barreto-Galeanoa et al., 2019). Research has also shown that the political leaders tweeting in segregated societies aim to "nurture peacebuilding and the de-escalation of conflict, or alternatively, to deepen political polarization and citizens' rejection of a negotiated solution to armed conflict" (Rodriguez et al., 2015). It is interesting, however, that a study that examined the use of Twitter both by social actors, including politicians, and by citizens concluded that whenever an incident occurs in the, despite the agreement yet segregated, society of Northern Ireland (Archick, 2022) which signifies the escalation of conflict, communication facilitated by Twitter seems to potentially resolve "sectarian tensions around contentious issues" (Reilly, 2016, p.10).

In this article we extend research on the political use of Twitter in relation to peace processes in two ways: (a) by focusing on the unexplored geographical context of Cyprus, where conflict is prolonged, and intergroup contact is minimal and (b) by adding another parameter in the analysis of the discourses produced in the community leaders' Twitter stream, that of an external geopolitical actor—the EU or Europe—which the leaders introduce in the dialogical process developed in their tweets to serve their political goals. This positioning of EU as a geopolitical actor in ethnic conflicts in the European area has gained renewed importance after the war in Ukraine and it is therefore a topic of increasing empirical interest in academia.

A dialogical approach

In this article, we are interested in how Twitter constitutes a unique arena in which to experience the Cyprus problem through the recontextualization of discourses in Europe. That is why, we are looking at the way the

Cypriot leaders construct meaning around these two concepts in their tweets. In order to do so we are adopting a dialogical approach that places emphasis on language as dialogue rather than as a system of signs (Markovà, 2016, pp. 1–2). We consider tweets not as means of transmission of fixed meanings but as interactive dialogs on certain objects of representation between what Markovà (2016) defines as the *Ego-Alter-Object* triad, drawing upon Moscovici's (2005) social constructivist epistemology taking multiple social representations in relation to each other and in relation to the *Object* around which they build their dialogue. It is through this triadic relation of *Ego—Alter—Object* that knowledge and dialogical tension is generated (Marková, 2006, p. 128).

We therefore see a dialogical relationship existing in the tweets as when one communicates through Twitter s/he is doing that as an individual who positions him/her self in the representational field vis a vis other positions. This positioning implies a social-psychological subject interdependent with others belonging to the same or different groups and in this sense, tweets are an expression of an ideological position with symbolic value (Duveen, 2001). Through this dialogical lens the discourses developed in the tweets are seen not as the fixed meaning contained within the text but as the result of a discursive recontextualization of meanings between the *Ego-Object* vis a vis *Alter- Object*. In other words, we see every tweet as a new dialogue between entities the meaning of which are constantly interdependent and jointly generated in a particular context. These entities are social representations of a collective self and others (outgroups) that every time they coexist in a tweet interact in order to produce systems of meanings.

In this article these entities are the two Cypriot communities who are in a constant dialogue recontextualizing the meanings of Ego and Alter through the utilization of *Object* or *Objects*. The most common *Object* around which these two entities are building their relationship and their related meanings are the Cyprus problem. In this research however, we are interested in looking specifically into how Europe or the EU becomes a second *Object* together with the Cyprus problem. We are interested in the interanimation or intertextuality of the following two triads: GCs-TCs-EU /Europe and GCs-TCs- Cyprus problem in order to establish, reproduce old meanings or produce new ones around all the entities involved. Furthermore, we are looking at discourses in which *the EU as an Institution with a voice and policy* instead of being a second *Object* in the triadic relation becomes a *third actor/party* in the dialogical interaction as EU sometimes takes an official stance on developments around the Cyprus issue and thus gets embedded in the discourse of the Cyprus problem as an actor. In this case, the triad becomes the following: EU-Cypriots (GCs-TCs)- Cyprus problem. *Ego—Alter* depends on not only in terms of *Objects* that affect the production of meanings but also in terms of roles they obtain within the dialogical relation. The *third party* according to Markovà "refers to someone or something that suggests a solution to the problem in question [. . .] [and] can also benefit from its position as a negotiator" (2006, p. 131). This third party sometimes enters the existing dialogical relation of the *Ego—Alter—Object* either from the outside, i.e., as an entity that is "physically present" in their dialogue, or it enters as an inside feature in their interaction. Thus, we are also examining the way this third party becomes present in a tweet either as an actual actor participating in this dialogical relationship of the two sides or as an actor penetrating the dialogue of the two sides from the inside, i.e., without being present only through the two sides' spoken words.

Specifically, the article attempts to explore the following research questions:

RQ1: How does Europe/EU, as *Object* or *Third Party*, feature in the dialogue within the leaders' tweets on the Cyprus problem?

RQ2: What discourses on Europe emerge in leaders' Cyprus-related tweets, and how do these change across timeframes with shifting prospects for reunification?

RQ3: By using Europe as *Object* or *Third Party*, what meanings arise in the Ego-Alter interaction within leaders' tweets on the Cyprus problem?

Historical overview

Efforts to join the EU and linkage to the Cyprus problem

Since its independence in 1960, Cyprus contemplated joining the EEC, initially hindered by Euroscepticism (Agapiou-Josephides, 2011). In 1973, an Association Agreement was signed, but the 1974 war disrupted plans. A vital link between solving the Cyprus problem and EU accession emerged in later decades. Despite the European Council's Corfu decision in 1994 to include Cyprus in the next enlargement round irrespective of a solution, Turkey's EU candidacy in the late '90s was tied to the Cyprus problem resolution. Turkey's evolving stance, influenced by the AKP party, led to two

distinct discourses in the TC community one nationalist, separatist and Eurosceptic and the other pro-solution and pro-EU (Agapiou-Josephides, 2011). Indeed, the Annan plan referendum campaign in the TC community in 2004 was essentially played around this ideological tension which brought thousands of TCs in the streets arguing for a solution on the basis of BBF (Annan Plan) and joining the EU against nationalists who preferred separation and closer ties with motherland Turkey seeing EU as a Christian club that cannot be trusted and could not be an unbiased mediator given Greece's participation in the EU.

Cyprus's EU accession

By 2004, the GC community unanimously supported joining the EU, but divisions emerged over strategic use. Pro-reconciliation forces saw the EU as a catalyst for a BBF-based solution, while hardliners, like President Tassos Papadopoulos, aimed for EU entry without resolution, using it as leverage against Turkey (Agapiou-Josephides, 2011). Cyprus joined the EU in 2004, yet the unresolved Cyprus problem hinders TCs' actual realization of EU membership. The accession of Cyprus to the European Union in 2004 significantly influenced relations between the GC and TC communities. Key developments included the opening of checkpoints in 2003 that facilitated movement and communication between the communities with positive effects on reconciliation attitudes (Yucel & Psaltis, 2020a, 2020b). Additionally, the provision of EU passports and IDs to TCs enhanced their integration into the EU framework, granting them access to rights and freedoms. These actions collectively promoted political dialogue and economic cooperation, contributing to a gradual process of reconciliation.

1st timeframe (April 30 2015–July 30 2017)

This article focuses on a period marked by intensive efforts to resolve the Cyprus problem. Newly elected RoC president Nicos Anastasiades (GC community leader) continued building alliances to manage hydrocarbon reserves. Through secret diplomacy, an agreement with Turkey was reached for a re-unified Cyprus on the basis of a Bizonal Bicommunal Federation (BBF) to ship reserves to Turkey and the EU (Drousiotis, 2021). Mustafa Akinci's pro-reconciliation stance in power led to significant progress in negotiations, culminating in the Crans Montana summit and UNSG Antonio Gutteres' proposed package deal, known as the Gutteres package. The Crans Montana conference played a pivotal role in the Cyprus negotiations as it brought the two communities and the three guarantor powers (Greece, Turkey and UK) very close to a peace agreement. As highlighted by Psaltis et al. (2019), despite the Crans Montana failure and the change of policy by the newly elected in 2020 TC leader Ersin Tatar's with Turkeys help and his turn to a Two State solution policy, a majority of voters in both communities remain open to the solution of the Cyprus problem on the basis of BBF showing that the positive legacy of this period is still influential as it showed what the vision of a reunited Cyprus as part of an EU could be despite loss of hope for a solution.

2nd timeframe (01 August 2017–23 October 2020)

This timeframe, starting with the collapse of the Crans Montana Conference, witnessed a blame game between sides, accusing each other of a lack of political will. After unsuccessful negotiations, a 26-month period followed with minimal initiatives to reach an agreement.

3rd timeframe (24 October 2020–30 May 2021)

The study's more recent timeframe, from Ersin Tatar's election in October 2020 to the May 2021 5 + 1 meeting in Geneva, reflects a significant shift. Tatar's alignment with Turkey's changed policy declared BBF as "dead," advocating for a two-state solution. This period marked a diminished hope for a BBF-based agreement, diverging from the decades-long peace process.

Methods

This study analyzes 3981 tweets from the official Twitter accounts of the Cypriot leaders N. Anastasiades (@AnastasiadesCY), M. Akinci (@MustafaAkinci_1), and E. Tatar (@ersinrtatar) using the Twitter API in R studio. Tweets related to Europe were identified through keyword searches in English, Greek, and Turkish, with a list of keywords available in Table 1.

Subsequently, tweets containing EU-related keywords underwent manual examination to ascertain their relevance to the Cyprus problem. The resulting 6713-word corpus underwent both thematic and discourse analysis. Thematic analysis revealed primary themes, while discourse analysis, guided by Discourse Historical Analysis (DHA) principles, explored specific contents, discursive strategies, and linguistic means (Reisigl & Wodak, 2017, p. 93).

DHA focuses on: (1) the specific contents of the tweets, (2) the discursive strategies employed, and (3) the linguistic means used by the leaders (Reisigl & Wodak, 2017, p. 93). This approach aids in

Table 1. Keywords related to Europe.

- Europe
- Ευρώπη
- Ευρωπαϊκ-
- EE
- EU
- Commission
- Κομισιόν
- Βρυξέλλες
- Brussels
- Avrupa
- AB
- Komisyon
- Brüksel
- Strazburg
- Strasburg
- Στρασβούργο

understanding how the leaders discursively construct meaning around Europe and the Cyprus problem.

The main themes that emerged from the data are:

(a) Role of the EU in the Cyprus Problem: Leaders constructed narratives around the EU's role as a facilitator in negotiations or as a necessary actor in addressing Turkey's actions.
(b) Interdependence of Cyprus and Turkey-EU Relations: The tweets highlighted the interconnectedness of the Cyprus issue with Turkey's EU accession process, emphasizing how developments in one area impact the other.
(c) Identity and EU Membership: The discourse reflected aspirations for EU identity, with Akinci emphasizing the TC community's desires and Anastasiades framing the GC perspective around the benefits of EU membership in the peace process.

The research adopts a critical and historical stance, examining the role of discourse in challenging dominance and exploring the discourses of Cypriot leaders across diverse historical periods (van Dijk, 1993, p. 249). The analysis specifically focused on identifying, examining, and investigating the development, strategies, and linguistic means of the discourse within the tweets (Braun & Clarke, 2006, p. 78).

Findings and analysis

The volume of tweets

Table 2's second column indicates high tweeting activity during the first timeframe, with Anastasiades posting 970 tweets and Akinci posting 925 in the 15-month period. Within these tweets, references to Europe were found, constituting 17.21% in Anastasiades' tweets and 7.45% in Akinci's. Notably, nearly half of Anastasiades' Europe-related tweets (80) also pertain to the Cyprus problem, whereas all of Akinci's tweets related to Europe are connected to the Cyprus problem.

Table 3 referring to the second period reveals a notable decrease in the leaders' tweeting activity, particularly in Akinci's case, where the total number of tweets dropped to 186, with only three referencing Europe and the Cyprus problem. Although Anastasiades' monthly tweeting ratio decreased from 5.33 to 3.69, his references to Europe increased from 17.21% to 20.20% of his total tweets. The percentage of tweets addressing both Europe and the Cyprus problem surged from 8.24% to 39.66%.

In Table 4, in the third and final period we note a decline in Anastasiades' overall tweeting activity over the seven-month period, while the newly elected TC leader, Ersin Tatar, exhibits increased Twitter engagement. Anastasiades' percentage of Europe-related tweets has decreased to 17.10%, whereas Tatar has maintained a very low reference to Europe (0.63%), as observed in the previous period. Among Anastasiades' Europe-related tweets, 20% are connected to the Cyprus problem, while all three of Tatar's tweets on Europe are also related to the Cyprus problem.

Discourse analysis

This section analyzes discourses identified in leaders' tweets across three periods, specifically focusing on references to both Europe and the Cyprus problem.

Table 2. Total number of tweets (April 30 2015–July 30 2017).

	Total number of Tweets	Tweets related to Europe	Tweets related to Europe and the Cyprus Problem	Monthly ratio
GC leader (Nicos Anastasiades)	970	167 (17.21%)	80 (8.25%)	5.33
TC leader (Mustafa Akinci)	925	69 (7.45%)	69 (100%)	4.60

Table 3. Total number of tweets (August 1 2017–October 23 2020).

	Total number of Tweets	Tweets related to Europe	Tweets related to Europe and the Cyprus Problem	Monthly ratio
GC leader (Nicos Anastasiades)	1198	242 (20.20%)	96 (39.66%)	3.69
TC leader (Mustafa Akinci)	186	3 (1.61%)	3 (100%)	0.12

Table 4. Total number of tweets (October 24 2020–May 30 2021).

	Total number of Tweets	Tweets related to Europe	Tweets related to Europe and the Cyprus Problem	Monthly ratio
GC leader (Nicos Anastasiades)	228	39 (17.10%)	20 (51.28%)	2.85
TC leader (Ersin Tatar)	474	3 (0.63%)	3 (100%)	0.43

1st timeframe (30 April 2015–30 July 2017)

In this period, the leaders' tweets construct discourses suggesting that the EU, though not an official negotiator in the Cyprus Peace Process, played a valuable facilitating role between the two sides. The discourses developed by Anastasiades, representing the RoC benefiting from EU membership, tend to portray Europe as a positive supporter and contributor to the efforts for a solution. Anastasiades's key discourses included:

(1) "The Cyprus problem is a European problem," arguing RoC's EU membership necessitates EU involvement.
(2) "Cyprus supports Turkey's EU accession if it fulfills its obligations," linking Turkey's progress to resolving the Cyprus issue.

As seen in the following tweets, Anastasiades directly asserted the first discourse, mentioning EU Parliament President @MartinSchulz and retweeting the European People's Party (@EPP). These mentions validate his message by associating it with influential EU actors and broadening its reach. He also indirectly conveyed this discourse by highlighting the EU Commission's role in solution efforts and emphasizing the Cyprus problem's place on the EU Council's agenda alongside issues like Brexit. This strategic framing aimed to solidify the EU's importance in the process.

In the second discourse, Anastasiades presented Cyprus's support for Turkey's EU bid as a given, using positive language like "will continue to be a supporter" and "while supporting." However, this positivity was juxtaposed with Turkey's outstanding obligations, creating a conditional stance. This tactic allowed Anastasiades to exert influence on Turkey-EU relations, leveraging Cyprus's EU membership.

> President @MartinSchulz & I agree that #Cyprus problem is a EU problrm & the solution should be in line w/ the principles & values of the EU
>
> (Anastasiades, 29 March 2016)

> .@AnastasiadesCY 'The #Cyprus problem, is a European Problem.'
>
> #EPPMadrid #Together
>
> (Anastasiades, 22 Oct 2015)

> At the seat of the Commission, meeting with the President @JunckerEU on #Κυπριακό . Η #EE ready to pleay its role.
>
> (Translated from Greek, Anastasiades, 16 December 2016)

> PM @ratasjuri and I had a chance to exchange views on the priorities of the @EU2017EE #Brexit #bilateral #CyprusProblem
>
> (Anastasiades, 29 May 2017)

The tweets below are such examples

In the two tweets above the discourse *The Cyprus problem is a European problem* is being developed in a less direct way. In the tweet dated December 16, 2016, Anastasiades sends the message that the core of the EU – *the seat of the Commission* – is not just informed about the Cyprus problem but it is also a role to play in the efforts of its solution *(The #EU ready to play its role)*.

The second tweet is an example of the way Anastasiades conveys that the Cyprus problem is always on the discussion agenda of the EU Council like other EU issues like Brexit and bilateral agreements.

The discourse *Cyprus supports Turkey's accession to the EU if it fulfils its obligations to Cyprus* is one that is being expressed explicitly and the two tweets below are such examples.

> Cyprus will continue to be a supporter of Turkey's accession path to the #EU, on the condition of course that Turkey fulfils its obligations
>
> (Anastasiades, 18 March 2016)

> While supporting the European perspective of #Turkey, this must be conditional on the fulfillment of its contractual obligations #Cyprus
>
> (Anastasiades, 30 November 2015)

What is worth paying attention on however in these two tweets is firstly the positivity with which Cyprus' stance is being framed. Phrases like *Cyprus will continue to be a supporter* and *while supporting* construct the meaning that Cyprus's support to Turkey is considered as granted, as something that always existed and that is undoubtable. Secondly, the way this positive framing is being contradicted with the obligations that Turkey has yet to fulfil in order for its EU accession to be materialized.

Akinci, representing the TC community's aspirations for EU integration, employed distinct discourses:

(1) "Our actions prove that we want a solution and an EU identity," emphasizing the TC community's desire to fully benefit from EU membership.
(2) "The Cyprus problem affects the Turkey—EU relations and vice versa," highlighting the interdependence of these issues.
(3) "EU will be benefited by the solution," stressing the positive impact of a resolution on the EU.

The aims of developing these discourses are better understood when examples of tweets expressing these discourses are further examined.

Here are a few examples of the discourse *Our actions prove that we want a solution and an EU identity*:

> The Turkish Cypriot community said yes to the solution and EU membership with a referendum. It was left out of the EU by another community's vote. there is no other example of this.
>
> (Translated from Turkish, Akinci, 17 November 2015)

Akinci referenced the TC community's "yes" vote in the 2004 Annan Plan referendum, contrasting it with the Greek-Cypriot community's "no" vote, to demonstrate the TC community's long-standing desire for a solution and, consequently, an EU identity

> We are committed to soltn of #CyProb & look fwd to increased coop w/ the #EU. In this context we had constructive dialogue w/@CorinaCretuEU.
>
> (Akinci, 16 October 2015)

He further reinforced this by expressing the TC community's eagerness for increased cooperation with the EU, validated by a mention to the European Commissioner for Regional Policy, @CorinaCretuEU.

> We talked with the President of the European Commission, Jean-Claude Juncker, on the importance of preparing the TCs for the EU while the solution process progressed.
>
> (Translated from Turkish, Akinci, 30 June 2015)

Akinci also argued that a solution was imminent, justifying the need for the TC community to begin EU accession preparations, a point he emphasized in discussions with EU Commission President Jean-Claude Juncker. Furthermore, Akinci explicitly stated the link between a Cyprus solution and improved EU-Turkey relations. In the tweet below, he subtly hinted at the nature of a potential solution by characterizing the EU-Turkey deal as "a result of the compromise culture," potentially foreshadowing the compromises needed for a Cyprus settlement.

There are cases that the discourse is developed in a very straightforward way like the tweet above where Akinci openly stated that the solution to the Cyprus problem will improve the EU-Turkey relations even more.

> The #EUTurkey deal reached as a result of the compromise culture is a positive outcome which is also helpful for the #Cyprus negotiations.
>
> (Akinci, 19 March 2016)

There are other cases however that the discourse is being developed entangled with other systems of meaning like in the one dated March 19 2016. In this tweet, Akinci directly refers to the fact that the EU-Turkey deal is helpful to the Cyprus negotiations constructing the meaning of the interdependence between the EU-Turkey relations and the Cyprus problem. Additionally, the fact that Akinci assigns the meaning of *a result of the compromise culture* to the EU-Turkey deal should not be overlooked as it could be argued that it works as a hint given by Akinci to the public of what the solution is expected to be.

Examples of tweets that develop the last discourse discerned in the tweets of Akinci, that of *EU will be benefited by the solution*, follow:

> Establishing peaceful future in #Cyprus will open a new area for regional cooperation.
> #EurasiaEconomicSummit #Istanbul
>
> (Akinci, 6 April 2016)

> United Cyprus will be able to serve as a hub for pipelines transferring natural gas to EU through Cyprus and Turkey
>
> (Akinci, 21 January 2016)

In these two examples Akinci states that the solution – *Establishing peaceful future in #Cyprus* and *United Cyprus*, highlighting the benefits of a solution for the EU, framing a "United Cyprus" as a regional hub for EU-Asia cooperation, particularly in energy.

2nd timeframe (01 August 2017–23 October 2020)

This timeframe follows unsuccessful attempts to reach an agreement on the Cyprus problem in Crans Montana (July 2017). In the subsequent twenty-six months characterized by a lack of active negotiations in Cyprus and escalating antagonisms between Cyprus and Turkey around maritime delimitation and search for gas in the Eastern Mediterranean as well as tension between Greece and Turkey in the Aegean. In this new context

both sides altered their discourses concerning Europe's role in the Cyprus Peace Process, evident in their tweeting activity.

Anastasiadesnstead of talking about the EU's involvement in negotiations, he started emphasizing the EU's job in controlling and acting as deterrence on Turkey's actions, both in Cyprus and the Eastern Mediterranean generally. Interestingly, he didn't use the word "solution" much during this period.

Here are the main themes Anastasiades expressed:

(1) "The EU has to stop Turkey's violations." He's arguing that the EU needs to step in to protect Cyprus (since it's an EU member) and also to show that the EU can back up its principles with action.
(2) "Turkey's bad behavior is going to mess up its chances of joining the EU." Basically, he's hinting at RoC membership in the EU and the possibility to push for sanctions against Turkey if they are aggressive
(3) "Turkey's got a completely different mind-set and is nowhere near ready for EU values." He's portraying Turkey as fundamentally incompatible with the EU in terms of values in this way evoking symbolic threats to his audience.

The first discourse is being developed by the GC leader in tweets like the following:

> Our country is not alone. Our position in the European Union is an important advantage that we use every day in order not only to strengthen our state entity but also to give answers to the Turkish challenges.
>
> (Translated from Greek, Anastasiades, 15 November 2019)

On the anniversary day of the "TRNC"[1]'s proclamation Anastasiades tweets to send another message of reassurance to the GC public. The reassurance comes through the RoC's European identity the importance of which is highlighted in the tweet by saying *the European Union is an important advantage*. This advantage means that Cyprus is not alone to confront Turkey's challenges—i.e., violations and illegal occupation of the island—but in partnership with strong EU states.

> It was with great pleasure that I received today its President @EUCouncil. At a critical time, amid ongoing challenges from Turkey, its presence @eucopresident demonstrates the decisive contribution that the EU wishes to make to bring peace and security to the region.
>
> (Translated from Greek, Anastasiades, 16 September 2020)

This reassurance is being confirmed by tweets like the one above in which Anastasiades also mentions the official account of @EUCouncil. The mention works as a confirmation as it automatically makes the tweet known not only to his followers and to the broader public but also to the EU Council itself and to its followers. In other words, the mention serves as a sort of validation of the reassurance that Anastasiades' discourse offers. Then Anastasiades continues to underline the way this verification of what he is saying is being materialized. He says – *his presence @eucopresident's demonstrates the decisive contribution* – underlying once again his discourse about EU's intention to stop Turkey's violations. Finally, in order to make his discourse even more effective he assigns the weight of responsibility to EU by saying that bringing peace and security to the region *is the contribution that the EU wishes to make*.

> Whenever #Turkey violates international law and undermines the vital interests of the #EU and its Members States, the Union should respond collectively and decisively in concrete terms.
>
> @EUCouncil #EUCO
>
> (Anastasiades, 17 July 2020)

Anastasiades reminds everyone that Turkey isn't just violating Cyprus's rights but international law as well, which reflects poorly on the EU. He insists that the EU needs to step up and act like a "union," a strong entity that defends peace and rights.

The discourse *Turkey's violations will affect its EU accession process* is another discourse detected in many tweets of Anastasiades. The tweets that follow are such examples.

> Its message @EUCouncil is clear. If Turkey wants to continue its relations smoothly in the framework of its accession process or in the context of other relations and actions, it must normalize its relations with Cyprus and put an end to the illegal actions.
>
> (Translated from Greek[2], Anastasiades, 21 June 2019)

In this tweet Anastasiades aims to draw the attention of the GC public on the fact that the message of the EU Council's decision was a clear warning to Turkey. A warning that in order for its EU accession to continue smoothly Turkey should normalize its relation to Cyprus and should also stop acting illegally.

> Positive and very constructive discussion today with @eucopresident Charles Michel and #EU Foreign Affairs Chief @JosepBorrell regardind Turkey's illegal actions and behaviour in #Cyprus and in the wider region and the impact on EU - Turkey relations.
>
> (Anastasiades, 12 June, 2020)

In the above tweet the discourse of *Turkey's violations will affect its EU accession process* is developed in a very straightforward way as Anastasiades directly refers to discussing with EU heads about *Turkey's illegal actions and behaviour in #Cyprus and in the wider region and the impact on EU—Turkey relations*. Adding the adjectives *positive* and *very constructive* to the discussion Anastasiades implies that the expectation that he cultivates to the GC public during this period about EU's actions against Turkey's violations having a negative impact on the EU–Turkey relations will be fulfilled.

> After yesterday's communication with @eucopresident I recently had a telephone communication with the President @vonderleyen @EU_Commission, in view of the visit of the Turkish President Mr. Erdogan to Brussels.
>
> (Translated from Greek, Anastasiades, 9 March, 2020)

> In a telephone conversation with Chancellor Merkel, in view of her visit to Turkey, I asked her to send a message to President Erdogan for an immediate end to the illegal activities in the Cypriot EEZ and for compliance, finally, with his decisions @EUCouncil.
>
> (Translated from Greek Anastasiades, 23 January 2020)

The two tweets above, are examples of how this discourse is also indirectly developed by the GC leader. Here Anastasiades says to the public that Cyprus has a say in the EU-Turkey relations since the contacts between the EU and Turkey are always done after a consultation with Cyprus. This indirectly helps in constructing a very specific meaning for the GC public: if Turkey misbehaves to Cyprus then the EU—Turkey relations are negatively affected.

The third discourse that has been identified in this timeframe has become visible in tweets like the ones below.

> The conversion of Hagia Sophia into a mosque is a direct insult to the world cultural heritage and to the international institutions. It offends historical memory, European values and disrespects the religious sentiment of Christians, Orthodox and non-Orthodox throughout the world.
>
> (Translated from Greek, Anastasiades, 24 July 2020)

In this tweet Anastasiades is juxtaposing Turkey's action of converting of Hagia Sophia into a mosque with the *European values*. The aim of this juxtaposition is to show that there is a great contradiction between the two as he assigns the meaning of *a direct insult to the world cultural heritage and to the international institutions* to the act of conversion.

> Neither Greece nor Cyprus seek escalation. On the contrary, what we seek is the rule of law. In view of the European Council, I hope we have the results we expect: peace, stability, good neighborliness.
>
> (Translated from Greek, Anastasiades, 14 July 2020)

Here, even though Anastasiades does not refer directly to Turkey he conveys the discourse of Turkey being polemic by emphasizing that neither Greece or Cyprus seek escalation. He indirectly contradicts the *rule of law* and *peace, stability, good neighbourliness* that Greece and Cyprus are *seeking* with what Turkey is causing in the region, i.e., international law violations and disrespect of the EU values and principles.

> These are the fundamental concepts that any state aspiring to become a member of our EU family should uphold and respect. We count on the support of all EU member-states during the EU Summit to take place next week in condemning these illegal actions.
>
> (Anastasiades, 7 October 2019)

In the tweet above, Anastasiades cultivates the meaning that Turkey does not uphold the fundamental values required to become an EU member because it violates international law with the way it acts against Cyprus.

Akinci produced only three tweets that related both to the Cyprus problem and the EU during this period. Even though three tweets are not enough to examine whether a certain discourse around EU and the Cyprus problem is being developed, the analysis which follows gives us hints of how the discourses around EU have been shifting during this period in the TC community also. Nor in relation to the TC positive orientation to the EU but as an expectation for EU to put pressure on the GC leader for the emerging handling of the COVID-19 related measures that deepened division between the two communities.

> Congratulations to the first woman EU Commission President Ursula @Vonderleyen. Best wishes with the hope to establish a friendly and productive dialogue on behalf of Turkish Cypriots with the aim to create a better and peaceful future for all Cypriots and European family.
>
> (Akinci, 17 July 2019)

In Akinci's first tweet, the feeling of hope is being expressed since his congratulations to the new EU Commission President are accompanied by his wish and hope for the establishment of a relationship between her and the TC community. Akinci moves on to describe the aim for developing this relationship and

through his description he expresses once again the TC community's desire for a solution and an EU identity as this we be *a better and peaceful future for all Cypriots and European family*.

> Now it's even clearer. This mistake must be stopped as soon as possible. We will continue to be in contact with the United Nations and European Union authorities regarding the issue. No one has the right to arbitrarily inflict this torture on both communities.
>
> (Translated from Turkish, Akinci, 29 February 2020)

In his second tweet, he is reacting to the chaos caused by strict COVID-19 measures at the crossing points between the two sides of the island unilaterally by Anastasiades who decided to close the checkpoints. He complains about these measures, calling them "arbitrary," and asks the EU to step in as a mediator to stop the hardship they're causing for both communities.

> The following is my assessment of the issue, which was reflected in the press and we have received information about, where the Republic of Turkey suggested that the Greek Cypriot Administration should address the TRNC Minister of Foreign Affairs instead of the Turkish Cypriot Leader regarding hydrocarbons in its contacts with the EU:
>
> https://t.Co/PYYSvUUHF0
> (translated from Turkish, Akinci, 16 July 2020)

His third tweet is a response to rumors that Turkey was planning to bypass him and deal directly with the TC "Foreign Minister" on EU-related issues concerning natural gas. While the original source he refers to is no longer available, his tweet reveals the growing tension between him and the Turkish government. Interestingly, even though he's expressing this frustration, he doesn't seem to be trying to reach out to anyone beyond his immediate circle, as his tweet lacks any mentions or hashtags related to the EU. This could perhaps indicate a sense of disappointment with EU institutions.

3rd timeframe (24 October 2020–30 May 2021)

In this third timeframe, that covers the period after the election of TC leader Ersin Tatar with the help of Turkey and their policy change away from BBF toward a Two States solution policy twenty tweets from Anastasiades related to both Europe and the Cyprus problem reveal three distinct discourses.

The majority of the tweets articulate a discourse that returns back to a solution discourse, "Our efforts for a solution are based on EU values, policies, and acquis." This discourse aims to convey the meaning that the GC side, represented by the RoC as a full EU member, is committed to seeking a fair solution rooted in EU values, policies, and acquis. Anastasiades often explicitly conveys this meaning in his tweets. Examples of tweets below illustrate how this discourse and its constructed meaning are explicitly conveyed:

> Now at the informal #EUCO in Porto, I am about to brief fellow EU Heads of State and Gov on the Geneva informal meeting on #Cyprus. We will continue to exert every effort to reach a viable and functional solution that will reunify Cyprus.
>
> (Anastasiades, 08 May 2021)

> Throughout my meeting with Mr Tatar, my position was clear that the solution that can be found is solely on the basis of the Summit Agreements, the decisions and resolutions of the UN Security Council and in accordance with the principles and EU values.
>
> (Translated from Greek, Anastasiades, 17 November 2020)

In these two tweets Anastasiades explicitly states that the solution should be based on the EU values, principles and acquis. The use of Europe as an intertext in this case aims in passing a message of reassurance to his GC followers and the GC public in general that the solution will be fair while at the same time passing a message of warning to the TC side and the international community that any other solution than BBF could not be accepted. Given rumors that Anastasiades had proposed behind closed doors to the foreign minister of Turkey Mevlut Cavusoglu a two state solution in Cyprus that he denied, this tweet also serves the purpose of convincing the international community that he is still committed to BBF.

> This attack on the French President @Emmanuel Macron by a leader of a candidate country is a brutal insult to European values and principles. The EU must face this new Turkish challenge together.
>
> (Translated from Greek, Anastasiades, 26 October 2020)

The second discourse discerned in Anastasiades tweets is that saying *Our efforts of solution are enhanced by our EU membership*. Anastasiades through this discourse reminds again the RoC's leverage due to EU membership. This discourse is conveyed more implicitly than the previous one, e.g., by emphasizing (a) that the EU heads are kept informed by the GC side on the development of the Cyprus Peace Process, (b) that EU partnerships and cooperation with other member states are being created that support the GC side's efforts for solution, (c) that EU officials often participate in the Cyprus Peace Process and (d) that EU plays the role of the facilitator in the Cyprus Peace Process. The

following tweets are examples of how this discourse is being developed:

> Now at the informal #EUCO in Porto, I am about to brief fellow EU Heads of State and Gov on the Geneva informal meeting on #Cyprus. We will continue to exert every effort to reach a viable and functional solution that will reunify Cyprus.
>
> (Anastasiades, 8 May 2021)

With this tweet Anastasiades informs his followers that he is going to brief the EU Heads of State on the developments on the Cyprus problem after the meeting on Cyprus in Geneva. The message conveyed here is that the EU Heads are always kept updated and involved in the Cyprus problem by the GC side and that is why they are always ready to support the GC which is represented by the RoC.

> I expressed my deep appreciation to @Emmanuel Macron for his personal interest & support in efforts to resume the negotiating process. As close partners within the EU, Cyprus & France have developed an excellent level of cooperation in various items on the European Agenda
>
> (Anastasiades, 21 February 2021)

Similarly, to the previous tweet, Anastasiades tweets again to send the message to the public that the GC side, represented by the RoC, has valuable partners and cooperation with important EU states, such as France, and these partners are personally interested, care and support the GC side in the Cyprus Peace Process.

The other discourse identified in Anastasiades' tweets is repeating again the discourse identified in our second Timeframe, the one which articulates that *EU-Turkey relations are determined by the Cyprus Peace Process because of our EU membership*. In these tweets Anastasiades conveys the message that RoC's EU membership assigns the power to determine the EU Turkey relations. The tweets that follow are illustrative of how this discourse is developed.

> A constructive discussion w/ @eucopresident in view of his visit to Turkey next week. The following months up until the June @EUCouncil remain crucial for the future of the EU-Turkey relations, including the outcome of Geneva meeting for the #Cyprus issue later this month.
>
> (Anastasiades, 2 April 2021)

If we could put down the message sent by this tweet in its more simplistic form then it would go like this: The *EU talks to the RoC (the GC side to be precise) before developing a relationship with Turkey and that will be the case for as long as the Cyprus problem remains unresolved*.

> The Cyprus issue and Turkey's compliance with its obligations towards the EU and all its Members States remain key to improving EU-Turkey relations.
> #EUCO
>
> (Anastasiades, 25 March 2021)

Tweets like the above express the discourse explicitly and serve as reminders to the public about the leverage that RoC has over the EU—Turkey relations because of its EU membership but still unresolved Cyprus problem.

Now, the newly elected TC leader, Ersin Tatar is very consistent in pushing his two-state solution policy which is obvious in the following examples:

> President Ersin Tatar had a telephone conversation with the European Union (EU) High Representative for Foreign Relations and Security Policy and European Commission Vice President Josep Borrell. @ersinrtatar
>
> (Translated from Turkish, Tatar, 16 February 2021)

> SPECIAL | Former UK Foreign Secretary Jack Straw: We can start direct flights by taking a step towards recognizing the TRNC'It is a mistake for the European Union to accept Cyprus as a single country' Prof. Ünal: An intensive public diplomacy is needed indyturk.com/node/335761
>
> (Translated from Turkish, Tatar, 26 March 2021)

> It is necessary to remind those who still call a 'federal solution' for Cyprus, after the federations in Europe were disintegrated after 1989, 'everyone goes to Mersin, we go to Mersin, on the contrary'. I don't know what to say about the German reunification with reference to the fall of the Berlin Wall!!!
>
> (Translated from Turkish, Tatar, 15 April 2021)

He keeps repeating that a two-state solution is the only option for Cyprus. He's not just stating it; he's also providing reasons to back up his stance.

A deeper dive into Tatar's Discourse reveals Tatar's strong push for a two-state solution is a major departure from previous talks. This shift is closely tied to the rise of Turkish nationalism and Turkey's own change in policy on Cyprus. Tatar's discourse reflects this broader geopolitical context. It's not just his personal opinion; it's part of a larger trend.

The difference between Anastasiades and Tatar in this timeframe is obvious. Anastasiades is still looking to the EU, while Tatar is turning away from federal solutions and toward Turkey. This reflects the growing

divide between the two sides and the increasing influence of Turkey in the TC community.

Furthermore, Tatar uses repetition and assertive statements to normalize the idea of two separate states. He presents it as the only realistic option, aiming to reshape public opinion and close off other possibilities. This is a powerful discursive strategy to shift the conversation. Anastasiades, on the other hand, uses appeals to authority (EU leaders) to strengthen his position, trying to leverage the EU's influence.

Moreover, it's crucial to analyze how the EU is being positioned in this new context. Anastasiades wants the EU to be a mediator, but is that even feasible given Turkey's stance and Tatar's position? The EU's role is becoming more complex and contested.

In short, the third timeframe is characterized by a clash of discourses, with Anastasiades clinging to the EU and Tatar advocating for a two-state solution, driven by Turkey's changing policy. This shift has significant implications for the future of the Cyprus problem and the EU's involvement as it puts the EU to the position of the biased third party that cannot act as a legitimate mediator in to help resolve the Cyprus issue

Discussion and conclusions

Comparing leaders' tweets related to both the Cyprus problem and Europe across the three examined timeframes, a substantial drop is evident, particularly in the second and third periods, notably in the case of the TC leader. This decline serves as a crucial indication of a shift in how Europe is incorporated into the dialogic relationship between GCs, TCs, and the Cyprus problem, influencing the meanings generated through this triadic interaction. The almost complete absence of Europe from this dialogue in the TCs' case raises curiosity about its impact on the dialogic interaction among GCs. The ensuing discussion, delving into the discourses on Europe across the examined timeframes, sheds light on how the fluctuations in tweet volume have influenced both the dialogical interaction in the tweets and the meanings produced.

As previously mentioned, the first timeframe witnessed intensified negotiations and clear efforts toward a solution evident in both leaders' tweets. Consequently, the dialogical interaction identified in the tweets is characterized by a generally positive relationship between the two parties, namely the *Ego* and the *Alter* and EU as a legitimate broker to help the reunification of Cyprus

In Anastasiades' tweets, the *Ego*, while not explicitly defined, typically represents the GC community, which, in contrast to its *Alter*, the TC community, benefits from EU membership. This representation justifies the expressed expectation in the discourse that "The Cyprus problem is a European problem." This expectation assigns to Europe the role of a third party actively participating in the negotiating dialogical process, ultimately expected to "suggest a solution to the in question" (Markova, 2006, p. 131) which seems to be accepted by the pro-reconciliation leader M. Akinci.

In this initial timeframe, similar to other political leaders in conflict-ridden societies (Barreto-Galeano et al., 2019), Anastasiades utilizes Twitter to shape the meaning of Europe as a *third party*, both as an external and internal element, legitimizing its involvement in the negotiating process. Europe serves as an external feature when it has a tangible presence in the dialogical interaction between *Ego* and *Alter*. For instance, Anastasiades not only refers to what he and an EU official have agreed upon regarding the Cyprus problem but also mentions the official in the tweets (refer to the tweet dated March 29, 2016, in the analysis section). Alternatively, Europe becomes an internal feature in the dialogical interaction of the Cyprus problem when the GC leader refers to Europe and the Cyprus problem without explicitly explaining their connection. One method employed in Anastasiades' tweets to achieve this is through the use of EU and Cyprus problem-related hashtags, as exemplified in the tweet below:

> Constructive meeting between #Cyprus President @AnastasiadesCY and #Irish Taoiseach @EndaKennyTD, #Brexit, #CyprusProblem, #FutureofEurope
>
> (Anastasiades, 18 October 2016)

In this tweet, the third party does not have a physical presence in the dialogical interaction of the two communities that is embedded in the tweet with the use of the hashtag #CyprusProblem, but it is being added as an inside feature by simply adding the hashtag #FutureofEurope following the Cyprus problem one.

When Anastasiades develops the discourse of *Cyprus supports Turkey's accession to the EU if it fulfills its obligations to Cyprus* we notice a shift in the dialogical parts. The *Ego*'s representation shifts from representing only the GC community to represent Cyprus. This meaning of *Ego* becomes possible only when the *Alter* in the dialogical interaction is not the TC community but Turkey that needs to fulfill its obligations to Cyprus. Europe in these tweets usually becomes a *third party* as an inside feature since EU only becomes present in the

dialogical interaction through Anastasiades' reference to it (see tweets dated March 18, 2016, and November 30, 2015). EU through the words of Anastasiades is the family that will accept Turkey only if it fulfills its obligations to Cyprus. Again, here the legitimization and delegitimization (Barreto-Galeano et al., 2019) is obvious in the meaning constructed in Anastasiades tweets as he uses EU as the *third party* which legitimizes Cyprus as an EU member and delegitimized Turkey as an invader to Cyprus and candidate member of the EU.

In the 1st timeframe, Akinci strategically utilizes Twitter to foster the building and de-escalation of conflict (Rodríguez et al., 2015). His tweets distinctly aim to construct meaning around the solution of the Cyprus problem and the EU in a highly positive manner, framing it as a win-win relationship. In Akinci's tweets, the entities of *Ego* and *Alter* are more explicitly differentiated. The *Ego* in Akinci's tweets during this period is explicitly referred to as the TC community, which, according to him, desired EU identity but was left outside Europe due to the decision of the *Alter* – the GCs, who rejected the solution but still enjoy EU membership (refer to the tweet dated November 17, 2015, in the analysis section). Even in less explicit cases, Europe in this discourse developed by Akinci assumes the role Markova refers to as the *Object* in the triadic relationship of dialogical epistemology (2006, p. 136). In these cases, Europe represents the desired place to be or the desired identity for the TC community, achievable only through the solution of the Cyprus problem, presupposing the compromise of the GC community to accept a BBF solution.

In the discourse *The Cyprus problem affects the Turkey—EU relations and vice-versa* that has been identified in Akinci's tweets Europe is being utilized in some cases as a third party and some as an object. This is because sometimes Europe is being brought as an inside feature through Akinci's words into the dialogical interaction on the Cyprus problem (object) as a mediator of which its actions will affect the solution of the problem (see tweet dated March 19, 2016, in the analysis section) in other cases though the opposite happens. Europe, and in this case its relation with Turkey, becomes the object for which the Cyprus problem which represents the third party this time will become the mediator *A solution [. . .] will further improve Turkey's EU Relationships* (Akinci, December 1, 2015).

In the third discourse identified in Akinci's tweets, that of *EU will be benefited by the solution*, Europe becomes the third party again that might not be physically present in the dialogical interaction but through Akinci's words, it becomes the invisible mediator that while supporting the solution of the problem in question could also be benefited from closer collaboration with Turkey (see tweet dated December 21 2016, in the analysis section).

In the 2nd timeframe examined, there is a noticeable shift in the discourses on Europe in relation to the Cyprus problem evident in the leaders' tweets. Besides the substantial decrease in the volume of tweets, especially in the case of Akinci, the discourses presented in Anastasiades' tweets effectively reframe the role and significance of the EU in the dialogical interaction surrounding the Cyprus problem. Specifically, Anastasiades seems to subtract the TCs from the representation of *Alter* and to replace it with Turkey. Thus, in the dialogical interaction around the Cyprus problem, the *Ego-Alter* entities represent the European Cyprus (i.e., basically the GC community) and Turkey. To emphasize this shift of representations Anastasiades refers to the Cyprus problem only connotatively as a consequence of Turkey's polemic attitude. EU in the discourses identified in Anastasiades tweets becomes firstly the *third party* that should stop Turkey's violations against Cyprus, that will punish Turkey for its behavior by not processing its EU accession and then as an *Object*, a representation of values and ideas that the *Alter* (Turkey) does not abide by. He uses Twitter in other words, to produce a discourse that delegitimizes Turkey and shifts the responsibility of the unsuccessful negotiations process that took place in the previous timeframe in the context of the continuing blame game with Turkey since the Crans Montana failure. Analyzing Akinci's three tweets from the second timeframe through Rodriguez et al.'s perspective, which asserts that political leaders" tweeting in segregated societies aims to nurture peacebuilding, we discern that these tweets do indeed align with this objective. They constitute a desperate call to Europe to become the *third party* in the Cyprus problem process in order to put an end to TCs' suffering from (a) the international isolation, cost by the GC unwillingness to accept a compromise as the solution (tweets July 17, 2019, and February 29, 2020, in the analysis section) and (b) from Turkey's manipulative behavior (tweet July 16 2020, in the analysis section). The TC community (*Ego*) in this second timeframe's tweets of Akinci takes the representation of the victim of the negotiations' failure and Europe is called to act in order to end its victimization.

In the third timeframe which is defined by a leadership in the TC community which is both openly a supporter of a two-state solution and of Euroscepticism the three tweets included from Tatar in the discourse analysis section are revealing. What is noteworthy, however, is also a shift in Anastasiades' discourses that connect Europe and the Cyprus problem which is probably a consequence of this change in the

TC leadership and their rejection of BBF which allows him to comfortably become a pro-BBF supporter again. The solution of BBF makes a reappearance in Anastasiades' discourse. This time though, the desired solution is being objectified as a meaning that needs to be aligned with the representation of the EU values, principles and acquis. The dialogical interaction that exists in Anastasiades' tweets around the Cyprus problem the solution desired by the *Ego* (GCs) is one that represents everything that Europe is about in contrast to what the *Alter* (TCs and Turkey) suggest(s) the solution to be.

Furthermore, Anastasiades objectifies RoC's EU membership to develop the discourses: *Our efforts of solution are enhanced by our EU membership* and *EU-Turkey relations are determined by the Cyprus Peace Process because of our EU membership*. Through the objectification of the EU membership, Anastasiades assigns some sort of power to the *Ego* (the EU RoC/ the GCs) against the *Alter* (Turkey and the TC leadership) that changes the meanings associated to the Cyprus problem accordingly. This aims in maintaining the reassurance to the GC public that the two-state solution will never be accepted by him in an effort to thwart criticisms by internal opposition supporting that at some point before the collapse of the Crans Montana negotiations he had secretly met with the Foreign minister of Turkey and suggested a two-state solution himself. In other words, Anastasiades in this timeframe too seems to use Twitter in a similar way to the one of other political leaders in societies with conflict which according to Barreto-Galeano et al. (2019) to legitimize and delegitimize those involved in the conflict.

A significant finding emerging from this research entails a profound transformation in discourses concerning Europe within both communities. As the unfolding of this article exposed however, this shift is nothing but a *recontextualization* of the previous contrasting discourses already discussed in the historical framework section located around the idea of Europe in the past in both communities. Thus, in societies like the Cypriot one where a protracted conflict is central and defines its everyday reality, Europe as an entity becomes instrumentalised in order to facilitate the meaning that the discourse developed around the issue of conflict aims to construct. This recontextualization becomes extremely easy to be done through the use of Twitter by political leaders—and especially by the community leaders in the case of Cyprus—in a society in which the public sphere is segregated.

Our findings indicate that the dynamics in the Cypriot context reflect broader trends in social media's impact on political discourse. Research by Gainous and Wagner (2014) shows how politicians' Twitter activity influences electoral outcomes and engagement, while Aharony (2012) highlights Twitter's role in allowing leaders to communicate their agendas directly to the public.

This study also shows how leaders in conflict-affected Cyprus use Twitter to shape narratives about the EU's role in peacebuilding. As noted by McCluskey and Charalambous (2022) and MacGinty (2024), this adds to growing research on discourse analysis in International Relations.

Additionally, our study contributes to the discourse on Twitter's role in segregated societies, where it can either foster dialogue or deepen tensions. By examining Cyprus, marked by prolonged conflict and the influence of external actors like the EU, we emphasize the relevance of our findings to discussions on social media's role in shaping public opinion and political engagement in diverse contexts.

Finally, while our study focuses on the EU's role in the Cyprus negotiations, we acknowledge the importance of micro-ethical considerations in social media use within conflict zones. Issues such as misinformation, privacy, and representation are worth further exploration, and we encourage future research to address these critical aspects. Given recent rapprochement between Greece and Turkey and Turkey's effort to approach the EU again in the period 2024–2025 further research should explore whether such geopolitical realignments can bring new transformations to the public discourse around the EU in Cyprus.

Notes

1. The Turkish-Cypriot leader Rauf Denktas in 1983 unilaterally declared the Turkish Republic of Northern Cyprus, an entity recognized only by Turkey in the north of Cyprus.
2. "It's message" is the way Twitter automatically translated the Greek "*Το μήνυμα του*" meaning "the message of."

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